

John Wilkes

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John Wilkes (1725–1798) was a radical politician, journalist, and soldier, known for his charm, wit, and controversial life. Born in Clerkenwell, he studied in Holland and inherited an estate in Buckinghamshire through marriage. He became famous for fighting for voters' rights, freedom of the press, and the American colonists.

In the 1760s, Wilkes attacked the government and King George III in his newspaper, *The North Briton*. He faced legal trouble, fled to Paris, and was declared an outlaw. Returning in 1768, he was imprisoned, sparking riots at St. George's Fields. Despite being expelled from Parliament several times, Middlesex voters repeatedly elected him.

After his release, Wilkes defended press freedom and introduced Radical bills in Parliament. He helped control the Gordon Riots in 1780, though this hurt his popularity. He remained politically active until 1790 and died in 1798. Today, a talking statue in Fetter Lane, near Fleet Street, commemorates his life and achievements.



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